had declared the shivalinga to be ‘the phallic emblem of the male’. He then explained that this ‘thoughtless’ view had emerged in India ‘in her most degraded times, those of the downfall of Buddhism’, and that the real origins of the shivalinga lay in the *yupa-stambha*, the sacrificial post of the Arya, quoting a hymn in the *Atharva-Veda* describing the *stambha* as ‘beginningless and endless’, representing the eternal Brahman.[12] This divorcing of the shivalinga from its origins as a phallic fertility symbol became increasingly accepted at a time when Victorian-style prudery over matters of sex was becoming the norm among the fast-growing Indian urban middle classes, the new opinion-makers.

The Swami’s trail-blazing promotion of India overseas made him a great (and deserved) hero in his homeland, where his idiosyncratic reinterpretation of aspects of Hindu Vedanta, such as yoga and transcendental meditation, led to a new appreciation of Hinduism and of Indian nationhood that extended right across the political and social spectrum, from Mahatma Gandhi, who declared Vivekananda a great defender of Hinduism, to Vivekananda’s fellow Bengali, the freedom-fighter-to-be Subhas Chandra Bose, who proclaimed him ‘the maker of modern India’. Vivekananda’s sudden death at the age of thirty-nine robbed India of a blazing genius whose ability to inspire is still felt today.[13]

Swami Vivekananda was perhaps the most striking presence in a Hindu revivalist trend that was sweeping across India at this time hand in hand with nationalism. But also coming to the fore was another movement that was greatly influenced by Enlightenment thinking, best represented by the Tamil rationalist and humanist E. V. Ramasamy, better known as Periyar. Because he died in 1973 at the ripe old age of ninety-four we tend to think of Periyar as a relatively modern figure, but he was only sixteen years younger than Vivekananda, having been born